

Protective and Risk Factors of Late Adolescence

Introduction: The Forces That Shape the Journey to Adulthood

Every adolescent navigates a unique path toward adulthood. Some individuals thrive despite difficult circumstances, while others struggle even when advantages appear abundant. What accounts for these differences?

The answer lies in understanding two categories of influences: **protective factors** and **risk factors**. Protective factors are positive conditions or influences that help individuals cope with challenges, build resilience, and promote healthy development. They act as buffers against stress, adversity, and negative outcomes. Risk factors, by contrast, are negative conditions or influences that increase the likelihood of adverse outcomes, such as mental health issues, poor physical health, or difficulties in development.

Neither protective nor risk factors determine destiny. An individual with many risk factors can still succeed if protective factors are present. Conversely, an individual with many protective factors can still struggle if risk factors are overwhelming. The interaction between these forces — and the individual's awareness of them — shapes the transition from adolescence to early adulthood.

This reading material examines the types of protective and risk factors across physiological, psychosocial, and emotional domains. It also explores how understanding these factors can inform decision-making about education, employment, entrepreneurship, and skill development after senior high school.

Part 1: Defining Protective and Risk Factors

Protective Factors

Definition: Positive conditions or influences that help individuals cope with challenges, enhance resilience, and promote healthy development. Protective factors act as buffers against stress, adversity, and negative outcomes.

Characteristics of protective factors:

- Reduce the impact of risk factors
- Promote healthy coping and decision-making
- Can be internal (personal strengths) or external (environmental supports)
- Can be developed and strengthened over time

Examples of protective factors:

- Supportive family relationships
- Strong social connections with peers and mentors
- Good communication and problem-solving skills
- Access to education and healthcare
- Sense of purpose and future goals
- Healthy coping strategies (exercise, creative outlets, talking to trusted adults)

Risk Factors

Definition: Negative conditions or influences that increase the likelihood of adverse outcomes, such as mental health issues, poor physical health, or difficulties in development. Risk factors often contribute to vulnerability and challenges in coping with life stressors.

Characteristics of risk factors:

- Increase vulnerability to negative outcomes
- Can be internal (personal vulnerabilities) or external (environmental stressors)
- Often cluster together (multiple risk factors increase cumulative risk)
- Can be mitigated by protective factors

Examples of risk factors:

- Family conflict or parental substance abuse
 - Peer pressure and association with delinquent peers
 - Poor academic performance or low educational aspirations
 - Mental health issues (anxiety, depression)
 - Exposure to violence or environmental stress
 - Lack of supervision or consistent discipline
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Part 2: Domains of Development

Protective and risk factors operate across multiple domains of development. Understanding each domain helps individuals identify where they are strongest and where they may need additional support.

Physiological Development

Definition: Physical growth, health, and bodily functioning, including nutrition, sleep, physical activity, and overall health status.

Factor Type	Examples	Impact on Well-Being
Protective Factors	Regular physical activity, balanced nutrition, adequate sleep, access to healthcare	Positive physical health boosts confidence, energy, and emotional stability
Risk Factors	Chronic illness or poor health, substance abuse, poor lifestyle habits, lack of sleep	Poor health reduces self-esteem and increases stress or emotional strain

Key insight for adolescents: Physical health directly affects mental health. An adolescent who sleeps adequately, eats nutritious food, and exercises regularly is better equipped to handle academic and social pressures.

Psychosocial Development

Definition: The development of social relationships, communication skills, autonomy, and the ability to form meaningful connections with others.

Factor Type	Examples	Impact on Well-Being
Protective Factors	Supportive relationships (family, friends, mentors), good communication skills, growing autonomy	Strong social support enhances self-worth, belonging, and resilience
Risk Factors	Social isolation or loneliness, peer pressure, toxic or unstable relationships, social rejection	Isolation or negative relationships damages self-image and emotional well-being

Key insight for adolescents: The quality of relationships matters more than the quantity. A few supportive, trustworthy relationships provide more protection than many superficial connections.

Emotional Development

Definition: The development of emotional intelligence, coping strategies, self-efficacy, and the ability to manage stress and regulate emotions.

Factor Type	Examples	Impact on Well-Being
Protective Factors	Emotional intelligence, healthy coping strategies, sense of purpose, clear goals, self-efficacy	Emotional stability promotes positive self-concept and resilience
Risk Factors	Mental health issues (anxiety, depression), low self-esteem, unmanaged chronic stress	Poor mental health reduces emotional well-being and self-confidence

Key insight for adolescents: Emotional development is not automatic. It requires intentional practice — learning to name emotions, developing coping strategies, and seeking help when needed.

Part 3: Self-Concept and Its Role in Development

Self-concept refers to the understanding individuals have about themselves, including self-esteem, personal identity, and perceived abilities, traits, and worth. It consists of three components:

Component	Definition	Question It Answers
Self-Image	How an individual sees their actual self	" <i>Who am I right now?</i> "
Self-Worth	How much value an individual places on themselves (intrinsic)	" <i>Am I worthy of respect and happiness?</i> "
Ideal Self	Who an individual wants to become	" <i>Who do I want to be?</i> "

How Protective and Risk Factors Affect Self-Concept

Domain	Protective Factors Strengthen Self-Concept	Risk Factors Damage Self-Concept
Physiological	Feeling healthy and capable boosts confidence	Chronic illness or poor health reduces self-esteem
Psychosocial	Supportive relationships affirm worth	Isolation or rejection damages self-image
Emotional	Healthy coping builds resilience	Unmanaged stress creates helplessness

Key insight: When the gap between self-image and ideal self is large, individuals may experience low self-worth. Protective factors help bridge this gap by providing support, skills, and opportunities for growth.

Part 4: SWOT Analysis of Personal Development

A **SWOT analysis** (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats) provides a framework for understanding one's own protective and risk factors.

SWOT Element	Description	Corresponding Factor	Examples
Strengths	Internal protective factors	Individual strengths	Self-confidence, problem-solving skills, determination
Weaknesses	Internal risk factors	Individual vulnerabilities	Low self-esteem, impulsivity, poor stress management
Opportunities	External protective factors	Environmental supports	Access to education, supportive mentors, safe community
Threats	External risk factors	Environmental dangers	Peer pressure, family conflict, unsafe neighborhood

Applying SWOT to Personal Development

Question for Reflection	Corresponding SWOT Element
<i>What personal strengths help me face challenges?</i>	Strengths (Internal Protective)
<i>What personal weaknesses make things harder for me?</i>	Weaknesses (Internal Risk)
<i>What opportunities in my environment support my growth?</i>	Opportunities (External Protective)
<i>What threats in my environment put me at risk?</i>	Threats (External Risk)

Key insight: The goal is not to eliminate all weaknesses and threats — which is impossible — but to strengthen protective factors (strengths and opportunities) while mitigating risk factors (weaknesses and threats).

Part 5: Case Studies — Applying the Concepts

The following case studies illustrate how protective and risk factors interact in real adolescent experiences.

Case Study 1: Rico's Reality

Situation: Rico is 17 and lives in a community where many young people struggle with substance use. Some of his older cousins have dropped out of school and are frequently involved with drugs. His classmates have started pressuring him to join weekend parties with alcohol and substances. Despite this pressure, Rico is passionate about music. He practices guitar for hours and recently joined a youth band. His music teacher is supportive, and his mother always asks about his day and expresses pride in him.

Analysis:

Factor Type	Present in Rico's Life
Risk Factors	Community substance use, peer pressure, family members who dropped out, exposure to addiction consequences
Protective Factors	Passion for music, supportive music teacher, caring mother, youth band involvement, awareness of risks

Discussion Questions for Reflection:

- How does Rico's self-concept influence his decisions?
- What support systems are helping Rico avoid negative influences?
- If you were Rico's friend, how would you support him?

Case Study 2: Janelle's Journey

Situation: Janelle is 17 and in her final year of high school. Her grades are slipping, and she worries about college admission. At home, her parents argue often, and she does not feel comfortable talking to them about her stress. She scrolls through social media and compares herself to others, thinking, "*I'm not good enough.*" However, her English teacher noticed she was struggling and encouraged her to join the creative writing club. Janelle enjoys writing and feels better when expressing feelings through poems. One close friend checks in with her regularly.

Analysis:

Factor Type	Present in Janelle's Life
Risk Factors	Academic pressure, parental conflict, lack of comfortable communication with parents, social media comparison, negative self-talk
Protective Factors	Supportive English teacher, creative writing club, close friend who checks in, writing as emotional outlet

Discussion Questions for Reflection:

- How might Janelle's self-concept and well-being be affected by her situation?
 - What else could Janelle do to build more protective factors?
 - If you were Janelle's friend, how would you support her?
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Part 6: Applying Protective Factors to Post-SHS Goals

Understanding protective and risk factors is particularly important when planning for life after senior high school. Whether pursuing higher education, employment, entrepreneurship, or skills enhancement, individuals benefit from identifying and strengthening protective factors relevant to their goals.

Goal: Pursuing Higher Education

Protective Factors to Strengthen

Time management and study skills

Support from family and teachers

Access to college counseling

Strong mental health coping strategies

Risk Factors to Mitigate

Poor academic preparation

Financial constraints

Lack of information about opportunities

Test anxiety and performance pressure

Goal: Seeking Employment

Protective Factors to Strengthen

Communication and interview skills

Professional network (mentors, referrals)

Risk Factors to Mitigate

Lack of work experience

Limited job opportunities in community

Protective Factors to Strengthen

Reliable transportation and work ethic

Basic financial literacy

Risk Factors to Mitigate

Competing family or academic responsibilities

Unstable work environment

Goal: Becoming an Entrepreneur

Protective Factors to Strengthen

Problem-solving and initiative

Mentorship from experienced entrepreneurs

Access to markets or customers

Resilience and adaptability

Risk Factors to Mitigate

Lack of startup capital

Limited business knowledge

Fear of failure

Lack of support system

Goal: Enhancing Skills

Protective Factors to Strengthen

Self-discipline and practice habits

Mentorship from skilled practitioners

Access to learning resources (online or local)

Clear goals and progress tracking

Risk Factors to Mitigate

Lack of access to training programs

Discouragement from slow progress

Financial barriers to certification

Competing priorities and time constraints

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Protective Factors	Positive conditions or influences that help individuals cope with challenges, enhance resilience, and promote healthy development
Risk Factors	Negative conditions or influences that increase the likelihood of adverse outcomes
Proactive Action	Steps taken to prevent problems from occurring before they arise
Self-Concept	The understanding individuals have about themselves, including self-esteem, personal identity, and perceived abilities
Self-Image	How an individual sees their actual self
Self-Worth	How much value an individual places on themselves
Ideal Self	Who an individual wants to become
Well-Being	A state of overall happiness, health, and life satisfaction
Physiological Development	Physical growth, health, and bodily functioning
Psychosocial Development	The development of social relationships, communication skills, and autonomy
Emotional Development	The development of emotional intelligence, coping strategies, and stress management

Review Questions

Responses should be written on a separate sheet of paper.

1. Distinguish between **protective factors** and **risk factors**. Provide two original examples of each.
2. Identify one protective factor and one risk factor in each of the three developmental domains: physiological, psychosocial, and emotional.
3. Rico faces significant environmental risk factors but also has several protective factors. Which protective factor in Rico's life seems most significant to you, and why?
4. Janelle struggles with negative self-talk and social media comparison. What proactive actions could she take to strengthen her protective factors in the emotional domain?
5. Choose one post-SHS goal (higher education, employment, entrepreneurship, or skills enhancement). Identify two protective factors you currently have that support this goal and two risk factors you need to mitigate.